

Kanwar Kulbir Singh | BATHINDA | 26

Once a promising call centre executive, Kanwar Kulbir Singh languishes in drug-induced stupor today.

"I would get up at noon, eat, get ready and head for what I initially thought was heaven. I am now trying to come out of the hell."



30% of girls have abused at least one narcotic drug

jections. They sent him to a few de-addiction centres, but without any success. All was well till he passed Class XII, when he suddenly became convinced that there were no jobs, so studies were a waste. The family thought marriage might help but that too broke off after a couple of years.

Such sights and stories are common. Kin mostly just give up, after trying initially. In fact, in many cases, families get to know a little too late. "Unlike in the past, most of them don't do any physical labour. Then there is no source of entertainment. So they fall on narcotics and synthetic drugs," says IPS officer Praveen Sinha, who worked with the Special Narcotics Cell, Amritsar. Inspector General of Police R.P. Meena, who also heads the recently-constituted Anti-Narcotics Task Force in the state, says, "One big factor is unemployment. They have nothing to do. So they take to drugs. Peddlers see huge profits, and because there is demand, there is supply. Crime rates against both property and persons have gone up and it is also leading to more cases of hepatitis and HIV."

Recently the National AIDS Control Organisation revealed that Amritsar has the highest number of HIV-positive drug users in India. The national average is about 7.23 per cent, while in Amritsar it is 30.4 per cent. The situation in the rest of Punjab is no better. "The problem stems from affordability, availability and peer pressure. It is generally up to families to take care. But when fathers and elder brothers are already into it, who will stop the younger ones? Also, rural sports are dying," says Sherry Sabbarwal, professor of sociology, Panjab University.

The deteriorating record of candidates, particularly from rural Punjab, in police and army recruitment speaks clearly of falling fitness standards. When drugs run in your veins, you are good for nothing. Patiala's Bir Devinder Singh, 31, has represented the country in junior boxing and recalls the days when his punch was feared. He had an accident and became too restive, thinking that he would never regain his fitness. And "caring" friends ensured that he never got fit again by offering him "sulpha" first and smack later.

Alcohol, opium and poppy have been a tradition but now the addicts have moved on. According to the affi-

davit, "Opiates, their derivatives and synthetic opiate drugs are the most preferred ones followed by combinations of opiate and sedatives—poppy husk, smack, heroin, charas, ganja—and synthetic drugs—such as brufen, proxyvon, diazepam, combiflam, calmpose, morphine injection and syrups—which are easily available."

But how do the dangerous drugs land here? An official says, "The Iran-Iraq war led to stringent checking by European nations and the US for illicit narcotics filtering from Afghanistan and Pakistan. Drug traffickers thus changed the route to via India, of which 40 per cent passes through Punjab." A UN report puts Punjab as the new hub of drug trafficking in India. Traffickers use the cities of Gurdaspur, Amritsar, Tarn Taran, Ferozepur, Kapurthala, Hoshiarpur, Ludhiana, Patiala and Chandigarh to smuggle narcotic substances through the state. So, isn't the police doing anything? "You can always spot a police Gypsy near the drug supplier's place. That's not to check the criminals but to pounce on us buyers for their cut," says an addict requesting anonymity. A police official admits that many of his officers survive on peddlers' money. Recent cases, like that of Saji Mohan—who was zonal director of Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) here and was caught in a drugs racket and for embezzlement of Rs 14 lakh during his tenure—prove how deep the nexus runs. Only last week NCB, Mumbai, arrested suspended Punjab Police inspector Jagdish Singh and three others with party drugs worth nearly Rs 20 crore. Singh, a recipient of the Arjuna Award in 1998, wrestling, has represented India at over 60 competitions worldwide.

The state Government claims it has a plan up its sleeve, a comprehensive five-year action plan for 2009-2013. "We will hit the supplies for which we plan to strengthen our anti-narcotic infrastructure and also create public awareness," says Harjit. Meena adds the task force plans to seek support of other agencies and NGOs. Till then, however, drugs continue to be the religion of the masses. ■